Now or before? (am / is / are → was / were)

Name _____

THE BIG IDEA

If something is true NOW we use am / is / are, have, there is. If it was true BEFORE (and is finished) we use was / were, had, there was.

Если это верно СЕЙЧАС — am / is / are, have, there is. Если это было ДО и закончилось — was / were, had, there was.

How we build it

WHICH	PATTERN	EXAMPLE	РУССКИЙ
be	am · is → was | are → were	**I'm here. → I was here.**	Я здесь. → Я был здесь.
have	have · has → had | don't have → didn't have	**I have a bike. → I had a bike.**	У меня велосипед. → У меня был велосипед.
there	there is → there was | there are → there were	**There are trains. → There were trains.**	Там поезда. → Там были поезда.
Now: signals	now · today · at the moment	**She is tired today.**	
Before: signals	yesterday · last week · ago · then · in 2010	**She was tired yesterday.**	
must	must / mustn't → rules for NOW	**You must wear a helmet.**	

When we use it

Say how it is now: I'm ten. We have a dog.
Сказать, как сейчас.

Say how it was: I was five in 2020. We had a cat.
Сказать, как было.

Compare: There are cars now. There weren't any cars then.
Сравнить.

REMEMBER

Time words: yesterday · last week · ago · then · in 2010 → past. now · today · at the moment → present.

RUSSIAN AND ENGLISH

По-русски «был / была / были» меняется по роду, а в английском только WAS (I, he, she, it) и WERE (you, we, they). И «я есть здесь» по-английски тоже нужно сказать: I AM here.

Watch out! We often say...

~~I am at home yesterday.~~	**I was at home yesterday.**
~~He were happy.~~	**He was happy.**
~~I didn't had a bike.~~	**I didn't have a bike.**
~~There was two trains.~~	**There were two trains.**

EASY TRICK

Look for the time word: yesterday / last / ago / then → PAST (was, were, had). now / today → PRESENT (am, is, are, have). After didn't, the verb goes back to plain: didn't have.

Try it! Circle the right answer

1 I ___ at the park yesterday. (am / was)

2 They ___ happy now. (are / were)

3 We ___ a dog last year. (have / had)

4 There ___ no phones 100 years ago. (weren't / aren't)

5 ___ you tired yesterday? (Are / Were)

6 She ___ a bike. She sold it. (didn't have / had)

7 He ___ a phone yesterday. (didn't have / doesn't have)

8 There ___ a castle in 1500. (is / was)

Answers: 1 was · 2 are · 3 had · 4 weren't · 5 Were · 6 had · 7 didn't have · 8 was